



ranked the 11th-best team in the world and the third-best in the continent. Its last Olympic medal came back in 1980. The HIL played its part in providing a platform and bringing together the core of Indian players who would eventually go on to medal at the Summer Games in 2021 and 2024.

Mandeep Singh, Manpreet Singh, Harmanpreet Singh, Amit Rohidas, PR Sreejesh, Gurjant Singh, Hardik Singh, Lalit Upadhyay, and Vivek Prasad are double Olympic medallists who made use of the HIL as a testing platform before becoming mainstays at the international level. **Currently, India is ranked fifth in the world and the best in Asia over the last few years.**

Experts and former coaches have often cited India's lack of club culture as the primary reason behind its decline in hockey at the international stage, but the HIL, despite its short window, helped bridge that gap in its formative years.

Familiar territory: Kalinga Lancers won the last edition of the Hockey India League back in 2017. It is the only team from the previous version of the tournament that will be returning for HIL 2.0. AKHILESH KUMAR

"Look how good the European league structure is, and when players from around the world go and play there, the respective country's level also goes up," says India midfielder Manpreet, who featured for the Ranchi Rhinos franchise between 2013 and 2017. "You get the opportunity to play world-class hockey and learn so many things from there. If you play with good players, your confidence goes up."

While Manpreet had a couple of years of international experience before he joined the HIL, defender Amit credits the tournament for being the initial launchpad and later the turning point in his career. He still remembers the amount of money paid to him in the 2013 auction. "I was bought for 29,000 USD by Ranchi," says Amit, who is regarded among the world's finest first-rushers.

After his international debut in 2013, Amit was out of the national team picture for three years. "I had a dream, and that was to play in the

HIL and return to the Indian team once again," says Amit. In the following three seasons, Amit went on to win the title twice with Ranchi Rays (2015) and Kalinga Lancers (2017), including a runner-up finish with the latter in 2016.

"After 2017, I came to the senior team and have remained here since. In the senior nationals that we play, it's not possible to show the kind of talent you have. HIL is a platform that gives chances to players who don't get the opportunity to make it to the national team but have the potential."

HIL 2.0 instils the belief that it will continue to provide the feeder line for both the men's and women's teams. The launch of the women's league couldn't have come at a better time. After narrowly missing out on a bronze medal in Tokyo, the Indian team failed to qualify for the Paris Olympics. The team bounced back from the setback by winning the women's Asian Champions Trophy recently. The national team is ranked ninth in the world.

Feeder line: The HIL played its part in providing a platform and bringing together the core of Indian players who would eventually go on to medal at the Summer Games in 2021 and 2024. GETTY IMAGES

